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Deep Generative Models

Lecture 14

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Recap: Discrete Diffusion (Lecture 12)

ELBO

$$\mathcal{L}_{\phi,\theta}(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbb{E}_{q(\mathbf{x}_1|\mathbf{x}_0)} \log p_{\theta}(\mathbf{x}_0|\mathbf{x}_1) - D_{\mathrm{KL}}\left(q(\mathbf{x}_T|\mathbf{x}_0)||p(\mathbf{x}_T)\right) - \sum_{t=2}^{T} \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_{q(\mathbf{x}_t|\mathbf{x}_0)} D_{\mathrm{KL}}\left(q(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t, \mathbf{x}_0)||p_{\theta}(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t)\right)}_{\mathcal{L}_t}$$

Recap: Discrete Diffusion (Lecture 12)

Discrete conditioned reverse distribution

$$q(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t, \mathbf{x}_0) = \text{Cat}\left(\frac{\mathbf{Q}_t^\top \mathbf{x}_t \odot \mathbf{Q}_{1:t-1}\mathbf{x}_0}{\mathbf{x}_t^\top \mathbf{Q}_{1:t}\mathbf{x}_0}\right).$$

- Both $q(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t, \mathbf{x}_0)$ and $q(\mathbf{x}_t|\mathbf{x}_0)$ are known analytically from the forward process.
- The reverse process $p_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t)$ is a learned categorical distribution:

$$p_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t) = \text{Cat}\big(\boldsymbol{\pi}_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t)\big).$$

Austin J. et al., Structured denoising diffusion models in discrete state-spaces, 2021.

Recap: Discrete Diffusion (Lecture 12)

ELBO term

$$\mathcal{L}_t = \mathbb{E}_{q(\mathbf{x}_t|\mathbf{x}_0)} D_{\mathrm{KL}}\big(q(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t, \mathbf{x}_0) \,\|\, p_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t)\big).$$

Categorical KL

$$D_{\mathrm{KL}}\big(\mathrm{Cat}(\mathbf{q}) \,\|\, \mathrm{Cat}(\mathbf{p})\big) = \sum_{k=1}^{K} q_k \log \frac{q_k}{p_k} = \mathrm{H}(\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{p}) - \mathrm{H}(\mathbf{q}),$$

- $\mathrm{H}\big(q(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t, \mathbf{x}_0)\big)$ is a constant w.r.t. $\boldsymbol{\theta}$.
- $\mathrm{H}(\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{p}) = -\sum_k q_k \log p_k$ is a **cross-entropy loss**.

Therefore, minimizing $\mathcal{L}_t$ w.r.t. $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ is equivalent to minimizing

$$\mathbb{E}_{q(\mathbf{x}_t|\mathbf{x}_0)} \mathrm{H}\Big(q(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t, \mathbf{x}_0),\; p_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{t-1}|\mathbf{x}_t)\Big).$$

Austin J. et al., Structured denoising diffusion models in discrete state-spaces, 2021.

Setup: where PF-ODE solvers floor

Recall: probability flow ODE

$$d\mathbf{x} = \left[\mathbf{f}(\mathbf{x}, t) - \tfrac{1}{2} g^2(t)\, \mathbf{s}(\mathbf{x}, t)\right] dt, \quad \mathbf{s}(\mathbf{x}, t) = \nabla_{\mathbf{x}} \log p_t(\mathbf{x}).$$

- Plugging $\mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ into the PF-ODE and using a high-order `ODESolve` (Heun, RK) brings the number of steps from 100–1000 down to 20–50.
- Each step still costs one network call — truncation error compounds along the trajectory.
- Can we go further — to **1–4** steps?

Setup: shortcut networks

- Idea: **learn a shortcut network** that compresses many ODE-solver steps into one.
- It maps any $(\mathbf{x}_t, t)$ directly to the data-side endpoint of the same PF-ODE trajectory — one network call instead of many.

Two approaches in this lecture

- **Consistency Models** — enforce *self-consistency* along PF-ODE trajectories (per-sample mapping).
- **Distribution Matching Distillation** — match the *distributions* of generator and data via score differences (population-level).

Both reuse a pretrained score $\mathbf{s}_\phi$ as a teacher.

Outline

01 Consistency Models

02 Distribution Matching Distillation

Outline

01 **Consistency Models**

02 Distribution Matching Distillation

Consistency function: an ODE perspective

Goal

Learn a one-step generator $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} : (\mathbf{x}_t, t) \mapsto \mathbf{x}_\epsilon$ that pulls any noisy $\mathbf{x}_t$ on a PF-ODE trajectory back to its data endpoint $\mathbf{x}_\epsilon$, $t \in [\epsilon, T]$.

$\epsilon > 0$ is a small numerical cutoff — the score $\mathbf{s}(\mathbf{x}, t)$ blows up as $t \to 0$, so we stop one ϵ-step short and treat $\mathbf{x}_\epsilon \approx \mathbf{x}_0$ as the data sample.

Consistency function: an ODE perspective

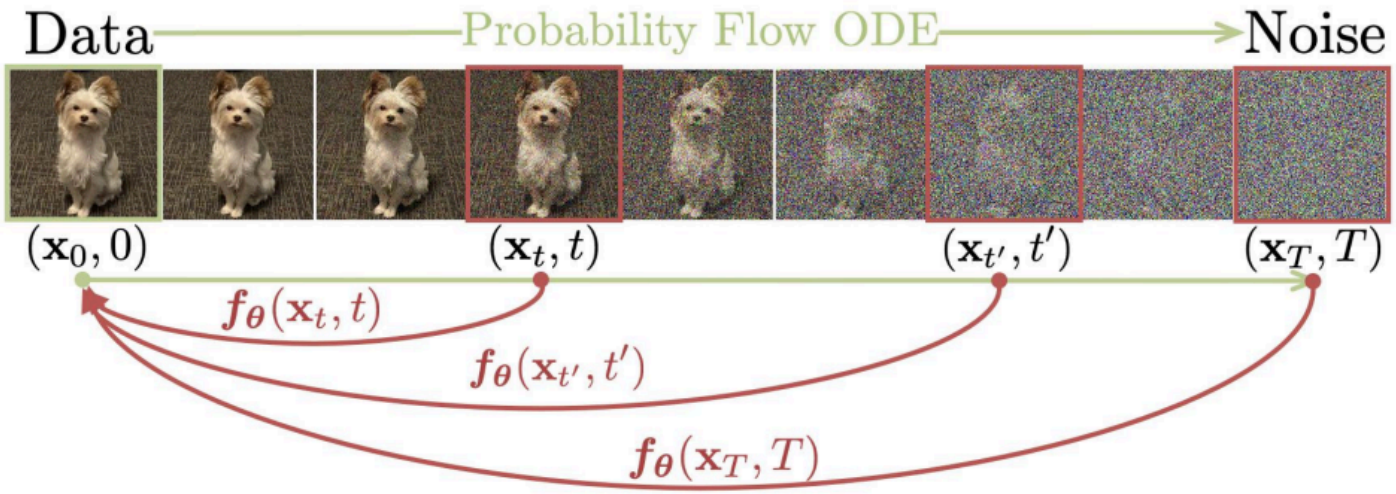
Specification: ODE problem along the trajectory

$$\underbrace{\frac{d}{dt} f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t) = 0}_{\text{differential form: constant along PF-ODE}} \quad , \quad \underbrace{f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_\epsilon, \epsilon) = \mathbf{x}_\epsilon}_{\text{boundary: value pinned at } t=\epsilon} \quad .$$

Together the two conditions pin $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ uniquely: a function that is constant on each trajectory and equals $\mathbf{x}_\epsilon$ at the data-side end must equal $\mathbf{x}_\epsilon$ *everywhere* on that trajectory.

Consistency function: an ODE perspective

$$f_\theta(\mathbf{x}_t, t) = \mathbf{x}_\epsilon, \quad t \in [\epsilon, T]$$



- To optimize the differential condition $\frac{d}{dt} f_\theta(\mathbf{x}_t, t) = 0$ we need a derivative through the network.
- Integrate it between two times t, t' on the *same* PF-ODE trajectory.

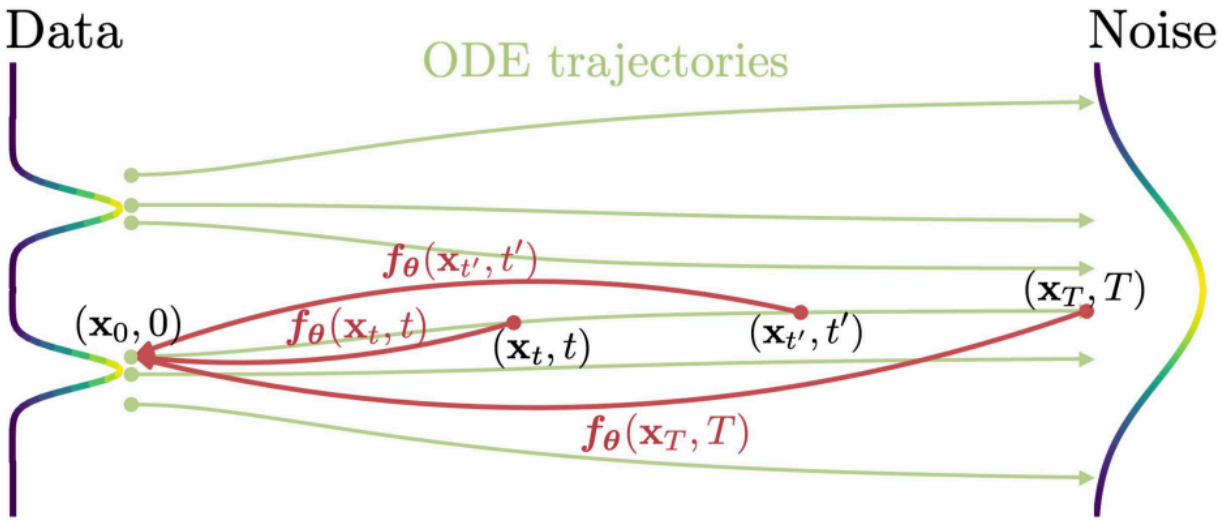
Self-consistency: the integrated form

Idea is to replace $df_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}/dt = 0$ by a finite difference between two adjacent points.

Self-consistency property

$$f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t) = f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{t'}, t'), \quad \forall t, t' \in [\epsilon, T],$$

whenever $\mathbf{x}_t$ and $\mathbf{x}_{t'}$ lie **on the same PF-ODE trajectory.**



Song Y. et al. Consistency Models, 2023

Skip-connection parameterization

Parameterization

We parametrize the consistency model to guarantee the boundary condition $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_\epsilon, \epsilon) = \mathbf{x}_\epsilon$

$$f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}, t) = c_{\text{skip}}(t)\,\mathbf{x} + c_{\text{out}}(t)\,F_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}, t).$$

- $F_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}, t)$ — free-form neural network.
- $c_{\text{skip}}(t),\ c_{\text{out}}(t)$ — differentiable scalar weights with $c_{\text{skip}}(\epsilon) = 1$ and $c_{\text{out}}(\epsilon) = 0$.

At $t = \epsilon$ the skip term passes $\mathbf{x}$ through and the network term is killed: $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_\epsilon, \epsilon) = \mathbf{x}_\epsilon$ holds *structurally*, for any $\boldsymbol{\theta}$.

Consistency Distillation (CD)

Enforce $df_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}/dt = 0$ as a *finite difference* on adjacent points of the teacher's PF-ODE trajectory. Discretize $[\epsilon, T]$ as $\epsilon = t_1 < \cdots < t_N = T$; $\mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x}, t)$ — pretrained teacher score.

One ODE-solver step on the empirical PF-ODE

$$\hat{\mathbf{x}}^{\boldsymbol{\phi}}_{t_n} = \mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}} + (t_n - t_{n+1})\, \boldsymbol{\Phi}(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1};\, \boldsymbol{\phi}),$$

one step of `ODESolve` for $d\mathbf{x}/dt = -t \cdot \mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x}, t)$ (Euler: $\boldsymbol{\Phi} = -t\, \mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}$; Heun: average of two stages). The RHS follows from the VE-SDE PF-ODE with $\sigma(t) = t$ ($\mathbf{x}_t = \mathbf{x}_0 + t\, \boldsymbol{\epsilon}$): then $\mathbf{f} \equiv 0$, $g^2(t) = 2t$, so $\frac{1}{2} g^2(t) = t$.

Consistency Distillation (CD)

CD loss

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{CD}}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \mathbb{E}\left[\lambda(t_n)\, d\big(f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}),\ f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}^-}(\hat{\mathbf{x}}^{\boldsymbol{\phi}}_{t_n}, t_n)\big)\right].$$

$\lambda(t_n) > 0$ — weighting; $d(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) \in \{\|\mathbf{u}-\mathbf{v}\|_2^2, \|\mathbf{u}-\mathbf{v}\|_1, \mathrm{LPIPS}\}$; $\boldsymbol{\theta}^-$ — EMA of $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ (stop-gradient target, prevents collapse).

Pseudocode (Consistency Distillation)

Training

1. Sample $\mathbf{x}_0 \sim p_{\text{data}}(\mathbf{x})$, $n \sim U\{1, N-1\}$, $\boldsymbol{\epsilon} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \mathbf{I})$.
2. Compute $\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}} = \mathbf{x}_0 + t_{n+1}\,\boldsymbol{\epsilon}$.
3. Solve one teacher ODE step $\hat{\mathbf{x}}^{\phi}_{t_n} = \mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}} + (t_n - t_{n+1})\,\Phi(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}; \boldsymbol{\phi})$.
4. Compute loss $\mathcal{L} = \lambda(t_n)\, d\big(f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}),\ f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}^-}(\hat{\mathbf{x}}^{\phi}_{t_n}, t_n)\big)$.
5. Update EMA target $\boldsymbol{\theta}^- \leftarrow \mu\,\boldsymbol{\theta}^- + (1-\mu)\,\boldsymbol{\theta}$.

Pseudocode (Consistency Distillation)

Sampling (Multi-step)

1. Sample $\mathbf{x}_T \sim \mathcal{N}(0, T^2\mathbf{I})$; denoise $\mathbf{x}_0 \leftarrow f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_T, T)$.
2. For $i = 1, \ldots, M-1$: sample $\boldsymbol{\epsilon} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \mathbf{I})$, compute $\mathbf{x}_{\tau_i} = \mathbf{x}_0 + \tau_i\, \boldsymbol{\epsilon}$, denoise $\mathbf{x}_0 \leftarrow f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{\tau_i}, \tau_i)$.
3. Return $\mathbf{x}_0$.

Multi-step trades a few extra NFEs ($M = 2$–4) for higher quality; $M = 1$ recovers single-step sampling.

Latent Consistency Models (LCM)

Apply Consistency Distillation to a latent diffusion model (Stable Diffusion).

Guided consistency distillation

Absorb classifier-free guidance into $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$: an augmented function $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t, \omega, \mathbf{c})$ takes the guidance scale ω as input. The teacher uses CFG:

$$\tilde{\mathbf{s}}_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t, \omega, \mathbf{c}) = (1+\omega)\,\mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t, \mathbf{c}) - \omega\,\mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t, \varnothing).$$

Skipping-step

Enforce consistency over k steps instead of 1:

$$f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+k}}, t_{n+k}) \approx f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}^-}(\hat{\mathbf{x}}_{t_n}, t_n).$$

Larger SNR gap $\Rightarrow$ stronger training signal.

Outline

01 Consistency Models

02 Distribution Matching Distillation

One-step generator

Setup

Train a generator $G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} : \mathbf{z} \mapsto \mathbf{x}$, $\mathbf{z} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \mathbf{I})$.

Objective

$$G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \# p(\mathbf{z}) \approx p_{\text{data}}(\mathbf{x}).$$

Distribution matching, not per-sample matching.

- CM ties each $\mathbf{z}$ to a specific PF-ODE endpoint.
- DMD lets $G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ re-organize the noise-to-image map — $\mathbf{z}$ and $G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{z})$ need not lie on a teacher trajectory.

KL gradient via score difference

Diffuse the generator output: $\mathbf{x}_t = G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{z}) + \sigma_t\,\boldsymbol{\epsilon}$. Let $p_{\text{fake},t}$ and $p_{\text{real},t}$ be the corresponding marginals.

Variational score-distillation identity

$$\begin{aligned}&\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\, D_{\mathrm{KL}}\left(p_{\text{fake},t} \,\|\, p_{\text{real},t}\right)\\ &\quad= -\,\mathbb{E}\left[\left(\mathbf{s}_{\text{real},t}(\mathbf{x}_t) - \mathbf{s}_{\text{fake},t}(\mathbf{x}_t)\right)\cdot \nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{z})\right].\end{aligned}$$

- Likelihood-free: only score *differences* matter.
- Integrate over t with weighting $w(t) \Rightarrow$ tractable training signal.

Two score networks

Real score (frozen)

$\mathbf{s}_{\text{real},t} = \mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t)$: the pretrained teacher.

Fake score (online)

$\mathbf{s}_{\text{fake},t} = \mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\psi}}(\mathbf{x}_t, t)$: a *second* score network trained online with denoising score matching on samples from the current $G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$.

Tracks p_{fake} as the generator evolves.

Alternating optimization

1. Update $\mathbf{s}_{\boldsymbol{\psi}}$ on a batch from $G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ (score matching).
2. Update $G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ with the score-difference gradient.

DMD1: total loss

Total objective

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{DMD}}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \mathcal{L}_{\text{KL-grad}}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + \lambda_{\text{reg}}\,\mathcal{L}_{\text{reg}}(\boldsymbol{\theta}).$$

Regression term

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{reg}}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \mathbb{E}_{(\mathbf{z},\mathbf{x}^\star)} \left\| G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{z}) - \mathbf{x}^\star \right\|^2,$$

on a few hundred precomputed $(\mathbf{z}, \mathbf{x}^\star)$ pairs ($\mathbf{x}^\star$ = teacher's PF-ODE output for $\mathbf{z}$).

Interpretation: regression anchors $G_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ near the teacher's deterministic map; the KL-gradient term then re-shapes the *distribution* of outputs.

DMD2: improvements

Three changes over DMD1:

- **GAN loss**: a discriminator on real images corrects the bias from an imperfect $\mathbf{s}_{\psi}$.
- **No regression**: removes the need for precomputed $(\mathbf{z}, \mathbf{x}^{\star})$ pairs; simpler pipeline.
- **Multi-step generator**: G_{θ} becomes a 4-step network, recovering quality lost at the strict 1-step setting.

Closes most of the quality gap between distilled and full-step diffusion.

Summary

- PF-ODE solvers (Heun, RK) floor at ~ 20 steps; further acceleration requires **learning a shortcut network**.

- **Consistency Models**: a neural network $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ specified by $df_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}/dt = 0$ along PF-ODE $+$ boundary $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_\epsilon, \epsilon) = \mathbf{x}_\epsilon$; CD enforces the differential condition as a finite-difference loss on a teacher's trajectory.

- LCM extends CD to latent SD with guided distillation and skipping-step.

- **DMD**: match generator and data *distributions* via the score-difference gradient; two score networks (frozen real, online fake) in alternating optimization. DMD2 adds GAN, drops regression, adds multi-step.

- Tradeoffs: CM is more principled, DMD currently delivers the best 1-step quality.